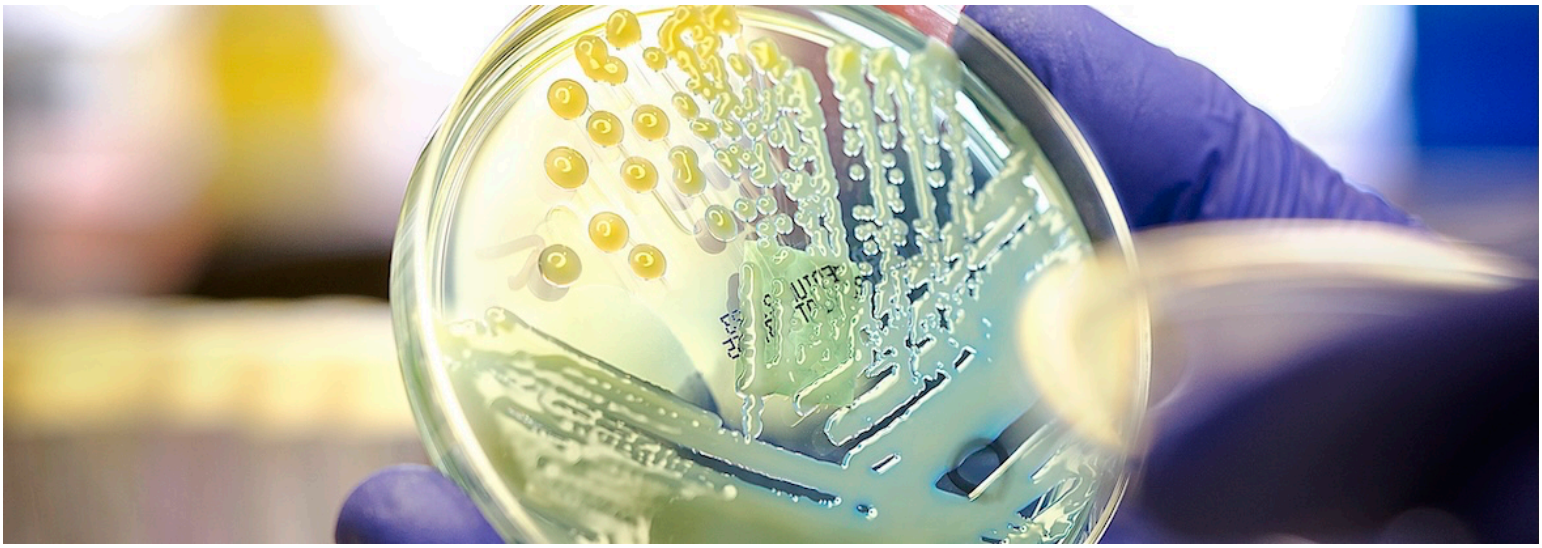
Department of Microbiology Quarterly Newsletter

April 14, 2025



Quarterly newsletter highlighting the Department of Microbiology at NYU Langone

Welcome!

Welcome to the first quarterly newsletter of the Department of Microbiology (name TBD)!

This quarterly publication will share updates on departmental news and events, celebrate the accomplishments of our colleagues, and keep you informed about upcoming opportunities and initiatives.

More than just a source of information, we hope this newsletter will strengthen our sense of connection and shared purpose—cultivating a spirit of community and inspiring greater engagement in the life and growth of our department.

The information below has been curated from the responses of your dedicated Content Ambassadors. As your representatives, their role is to collect news and highlights from their labs and submit a quarterly survey to help ensure the newsletter reflects the latest happenings across the department. If you have something to submit for the next newsletter, let them know!

Contact your Ambassador

A Note from the Chair



Ben, would you be interested in writing a quick little blurb to put at the beginning of the newsletter?

Our Newsletter Needs a Name!

Let's see if we can come up with a better name for our newsletter! Click the button to VOTE for names that you like, or suggest something else!

Vote or Suggest a Name!

DEADLINE: April 30th

Events

ONGOING

Micro Seminar Series

2:00 PM
Science Building
Room 103

Microbiology Seminar Series Calendar

Virology Group Meeting

10:30 AM - 11:30 AM
Every other Tuesday
Alexandria Center
Conference Room 508

Virology Group Meeting Schedule

FRIDAY, APRIL 18

The Departments of Microbiology and Cell Biology present the

2025 Vilcek Prize in Biomedical Science Lecture

12:00 PM - 1:00 PM
Alumni Hall 1st Floor, Hall B



2025 Vilcek Prize in Biomedical Science Lecture:

"Tempting fate: neural crest stem cell contributions along the body axis"

Marianne Bronner, PhD
Edward B. Lewis Professor of Biology Director of the Beckman Institute, California Institute of Technology

Hosted by Heran Darwin
Coffee and cookies will be served

FRIDAY, MAY 16

Departmental Retreat

9:00 AM - 4:30 PM
Location TBD

The Department of Microbiology is hosting an all-day team-building retreat filled with fun games, interesting speakers, good company, and a little bit of science too!

Department Short Talks. Buckle up for this rapid-fire showcase where some of our brilliant in-house minds hit you with their latest research in just 15 minutes flat. No fluff, just the good stuff.

Micro Lab Trivia Contest. Think you know your microbes *and* your department? Put your trivia chops to the test in this battle of wits.

Microbiology Mic Drop. Students and Postdocs will have three minutes to explain what they do and why it matters using only a single slide before getting gonged off stage. Prepare, or wing it...the result is sure to be hilariously informative.

Don't miss this fun-filled day of getting to know your department-mates! You might even learn a thing or two!

MONDAY, JUNE 9

Thesis Defense

Save the Date!

Julia Sproch, a graduate student in the Ratner lab, has scheduled her thesis defense for June 9th.

Conferences

Immunology 2025

May 3 - 7, 2025: Honolulu, HI
Annual meeting of the American Association of

ASGCT 2025

May 13 - 17, 2025: New Orleans, LA
28th annual meeting of the American Society of

Immunologists (AAI) held at the Hawai'i Convention Center in Honolulu.

Who's presenting: **Mimi Kostoska**

Europneumo 2025

May 20 - 23, 2025: São Miguel, Azores
17th European Meeting on the Molecular Biology of the Pneumococcus, a forum for the exchange of cutting-edge insights into *Streptococcus pneumoniae*.

Who's presenting: **Teni Idowu**

FOCIS 2025

June 24 - 27, 2025: Boston, MA
25th Annual Meeting of the Federation of Clinical Immunology Societies

Who's presenting: **Kamal Khanna, PhD**

Gene and Cell Therapy (ASGCT), held at the Ernest N. Morial Convention Center in New Orleans.

ASM Microbe 2025

June 19 - 23, 2025: Los Angeles, CA
Annual meeting of the American Society for Microbiology. Topics include: Microbes in the Wild, Microbial Chemistry, Innovative Methods for Discovery, Microbes and Human Health from Basic Science Perspective, Omics, and more.

ASV 2025

July 14 - 17, 2025: Montréal, Québec
44th annual meeting of the American Society for Virology, hosted by McGill University and held at the Palais des congrès de Montréal.

Who's presenting: **Grace Ciabattoni**, **Stacey Bartlett PhD**, **Mila Ortigoza PhD**, **Ryla Cantergiani**, **Morganne Baldaccini PhD**, **Leon Hsieh PhD**, and **Sydney Pimentel**

Department Updates

New Initiatives

Microbiology Postdoc Mini-Symposium

The Department of Microbiology postdocs held a one-day mini-symposium on February 20th to share their work and get to know each other better. The symposium featured 15-minute talks by **Drs. Stacey Bartlett**, **Daisy Ji**, **Alexis Sommerfield, Alvaro Fajardo, Hannes Eichner, Aaron Oom, Melanie Mahe, and Denise Ohnezeit**.

The symposium also featured a Career Panel, where postdocs could ask questions and chat with speakers from NYC DOHMH and the science education/communication and industry sectors.

Launch of the Departmental Newsletter

We're excited to launch the first edition of our departmental newsletter—an effort conceptualized by Dr. tenOever at our first Postdoc Lunch and made possible by a small but mighty team!

About the editors:

• **Judy Minkoff, PhD** just marked three years as a remote postdoc in the tenOever lab, supporting grant, manuscript, and presentation development, and leading projects like the lab Wiki and this newsletter. She earned her PhD in Immunology and Molecular Pathogenesis from Emory, studying measles virus at the CDC under the supervision of Paul Rota, and completed postdocs at USUHS (KSHV) and WCMC (lentiviral-vectored influenza vaccines). After two years as a medical writer and a career break to raise a family, she returned to science, thanks to Dr. tenOever's support. Dr. Minkoff set up JungleMail, runs the *Microbiology Roundup* email survey, designs and writes content for the newsletter, and bravely hits "send."

• **Emily Dembinski** is a third year PhD candidate in the Ratner lab studying Group B *Streptococcus*. She did her undergraduate studies at UCLA, where she worked as a design and illustrations editor for student-run newspaper, The Daily Bruin. Emily helps refine the newsletter and serves as an on-site point-of-contact for stories.

If you'd like to join the team, we'd love your support—just reach out.

Departmental Wiki

We are working towards developing a Departmental Wiki page in the months ahead. Stay tuned.

Equipment and Facilities

Not final yet, but the Department may be receiving some new equipment pending OSR approval when the Department moves into its designated space on floors 3-5 in ACLS-W. ☝🏻

Spotlight on Success

Trainee News

Dounia Abbadi, PhD



PI News

Congratulations to our Innovators!



On April 10th, several members of our department were recognized at the NYU

Dr. Abbadi, a postdoc in the Schneider lab, is one of three world-wide winners of this year's BioInnovation Institute and Science Prize for Innovation. The prize, which honors bold researchers at the intersection of entrepreneurship and life sciences, is awarded annually by the BioInnovation Institute in Copenhagen, Denmark and the editors of *Science*. The award ceremony on April 29th will be attended by the King of Denmark and former Mayer of Copenhagen.

Dr. Abbadi's research forms the foundational science for Regerna Therapeutics, a near-clinical stage regenerative medicine biotechnology company and NYU Langone spinout that she cofounded with Dr. Schneider. Regerna is developing first-in-class regenerative mRNA binding protein therapeutics to repair and regenerate muscle lost to atrophy in aging, severe injury, muscular dystrophies, and GLP1 agonist use.

See her feature in Science Magazine!

Kelly Crotty, PhD

Dr. Crotty from the Rodriguez lab successfully defended her PhD thesis entitled, "Role of *Plasmodium falciparum* Hemozoin-Associated Lipids in the Pathogenesis of Cerebral Malaria."

Payal Damani-Yokota, PhD

Dr. Damani-Yokota, a postdoc in the Khanna lab, received a scholarship and presented a short talk at the Keystone Symposia for Innate Immune Memory: Mechanisms and Consequences (Feb 2-6) in Vancouver, Canada

Leon Hsieh, PhD

A postdoc in the tenOever lab, Dr. Hsieh was selected for a scholarship to attend this year's RIKEN Center for Integrative Medical Sciences

Langone Health Innovators' Dinner. Hosted by Technology Opportunities & Ventures (TOV), the evening was an occasion to honor the institution's leading innovators and entrepreneurs, and to celebrate the translation of ideas generated through NYU Grossman SOM and NYU Langone research.

Congratulations to the 2024 contributors who were honored:

Innovator of the Year:
Jan Vilček, MD, PhD, for his remarkable contributions to biomedical research and the commercialization of life-changing therapeutics. Future awards will be presented as the "Jan Vilček Innovator of the Year" in recognition of Dr. Vilcek's lifetime of service to NYU.

Startup of the Year:
Ian Mohr, PhD for BeneVir Biopharm. Founded in 2011, BeneVir utilizes Dr. Mohr's T-Stealth™ Oncolytic Virus Platform designed to selectively kill cancer cells while evading immune detection. BeneVir was acquired by Johnson & Johnson's Janssen Biotech (now J&J Innovative Medicine) in one of the largest exit events in NYU Langone's startup history.

Innovators on License Agreements:
Joel Belasco, PhD
Ian Mohr, PhD

Inventors on Issued Patents:
Nathaniel Landau, PhD
Takuya Tada, PhD
Ian Mohr, PhD
Angus Wilson, PhD

Learn more about the dinner and other honorees.

Heran Darwin, PhD

(IMS) meeting in Japan.

Teni Idowu

Teni, a graduate student in the Weiser lab, was chosen to speak at Europneumo 2025. Teni was also one of eight PhD students chosen to present on April 9th at NYU's PhD Live!, a university-wide competition in which students give a three-minute talk on their research to a general audience.

Judy Minkoff, PhD



Last fall, Dr. Minkoff, a postdoc in the tenOever lab, performed in an Off-Broadway show about antimicrobial resistance and the discovery of penicillin by Alexander Fleming. The show was called Lifeline, and it was a great opportunity for the tenOever lab to get together.

Denise Ohnezeit, PhD

Dr. Ohnezeit in the Mohr/Wilson lab recently received a Walter-Benjamin DFG Fellowship, which enables researchers in the postdoctoral training phase to secure independent funding for their own research project, paving the way for future autonomy in their scientific career.

Daisy Ji, PhD

Dr. Ji, a postdoc in the H. Darwin lab, presented her work as a short talk on copper susceptibility in *M. tuberculosis* at the



Recognizing the unmet need for a meeting on the fundamental biology of mycobacteria and related genera, Dr. H Darwin began developing a new Gordon Research Conference (GRC) in 2019 with her colleague, Dr. Michael Glickman. Delayed by the pandemic, the proposal was submitted in 2022 and approved the following year. The inaugural GRC on the Biology of Mycobacteria took place April 6-11, 2025, in Pomona, CA. Despite ongoing uncertainty around travel and NIH funding, the meeting drew a global audience and surpassed attendance expectations. With all 200 spots—the maximum allowed for any GRC—filled, the event was officially oversubscribed!

Notable speakers at the event included Graham Hatfull of "SEA-PHAGES" fame and who was elected to the US National Academy of Sciences last year, and former NYU faculty member, Damian Ekiert PhD, who presented structural work on the mycobacterial MCE system.

Kamal Khanna, PhD

Dr. Khanna was awarded an NIH NIAID R01 to support his research on Type 2 Immunity.

Robert J. Schneider, PhD

inaugural Gordon Research Conference on the Biology of Mycobacteria.

Phuong Tran, PhD

Dr. Tran, a postdoc in the H. Darwin lab, presented a poster on aldehyde resistance at the inaugural Gordon Research Conference on the Biology of Mycobacteria.



A recent article on Dr. Schneider's Duchenne muscular dystrophy program was featured in the international patient forum, DMD Warriors. The approach has generated excitement among the Duchenne community, as current gene therapies offer limited—if any—therapeutic benefit.

Dr. Schneider also successfully renewed his Breast Cancer Research Foundation grant, "The m6A and non-canonical mRNA translation initiation axis in breast cancer metastasis," securing 5 more years of funding.

New Faces



James Lee, PhD

We are pleased to welcome Dr. James Lee as a new PI in the department. Dr. Lee joins us from the The Rockefeller University, where his postdoctoral research in the Chen laboratory focused on the structural and mechanistic basis of host-pathogen interactions. Using protein engineering and chemical biology strategies, he determined cryo-EM structures of membrane protein complexes involved in pathogen virulence and immune

recognition, revealing insights into how antigen presentation is modulated during viral and bacterial infections.

Dr. Lee received his B.S./M.S. in Molecular Biophysics and Biochemistry from Yale University in 2012 and his Ph.D. in Biochemistry from Harvard University in 2018 under the supervision of Daniel Kahne. He will be starting his lab at NYU Langone this fall.



Eduardo D. Bernier

Eduardo recently joined the Khanna lab as a Research Associate. He will focus on the study and characterization of tumor-specific T cells in the metastatic B16 melanoma lung model. Eduardo was born and raised in Guayama, PR.



Frédérique Braun, PhD

Dr. Braun, a faculty member at the Université Paris Cité and investigator at the Institut de Biologie Physico-Chimique, arrived in March for a three-month sabbatical in the Belasco lab.



Mark Chua, PhD

Dr. Chua recently joined the tenOever lab as a Senior Scientist to work on an NIH-sponsored research effort to develop a universal Influenza virus vaccine.



Daniel Fecko

Daniel, a recent graduate from the University of Chicago and native of the Chicago suburbs, joined the Weiser lab as a Research Associate.



Ryan Gado

Ryan, a first year graduate student, started his rotation in the H. Darwin lab in April.



Zeineb M'hamdi, PhD

Dr. Mhamdi joined the Ortigoza lab as a postdoc. Her work will focus on developing a new animal model to understand how the

mammary gland could serve as a novel reservoir for highly pathogenic H5N1 influenza.



Stephen T. Yeung, PhD

Dr. Yeung, a Senior Research Scientist from the Khanna lab, joined the faculty at Weill Cornell as an Assistant Professor of Medicine.

Fond Farewells



Caroline Abbud

Caroline, a talented technician in the tenOever lab, will be leaving to work at Pfizer. She will be missed, but we wish her the best.



Surya Aggarwal, PhD

Dr. Aggarwal, a post-doctoral fellow, left the Weiser lab in January for a new position as a Senior Scientist at Merck in Philadelphia.



Eric Bartnicki, PhD

Dr. Bartnicki, a graduate student who defended his thesis in October, left the Khanna lab to take a position as Scientist I at Envisagenics.

New Publications

Pironti Lab

Enterobacter hormaechei replaces virulence with carbapenem resistance via porin loss.
Perault et al. **PNAS**

Schneider Lab

mRNA binding proteins join the longevity pipeline: Rebuilding muscle through the power of mRNA binding protein therapeutics.
Abbadi Prize Essay. **Science**

Stapleford Lab

Differential restriction of chikungunya virus in primary human cardiac endothelial cells occurs at multiple steps in the viral life cycle.
Spector et al. **PLoS Negl Trop Dis**.

Weiser Lab

Intra-serotype variation of Streptococcus pneumoniae capsule and its quantification. Eichner et al. **Microbiol Spectr**

Alumni

Characterization of a cytokinin-binding protein locus in Mycobacterium tuberculosis. Yoo et al. **J Bacteriol**
Jin Hee Yoo was a tech in the H. Darwin lab and is now a PhD student at UC Berkeley.

Identification of a depupylation regulator for an essential enzyme in Mycobacterium tuberculosis.
Kahne et al. **PNAS**
Shoshanna was a graduate student in the H. Darwin lab and is now a postdoc at UW in Alex Meeske's lab.

JUST FOR FUN 😄

Spring-themed Food Ideas



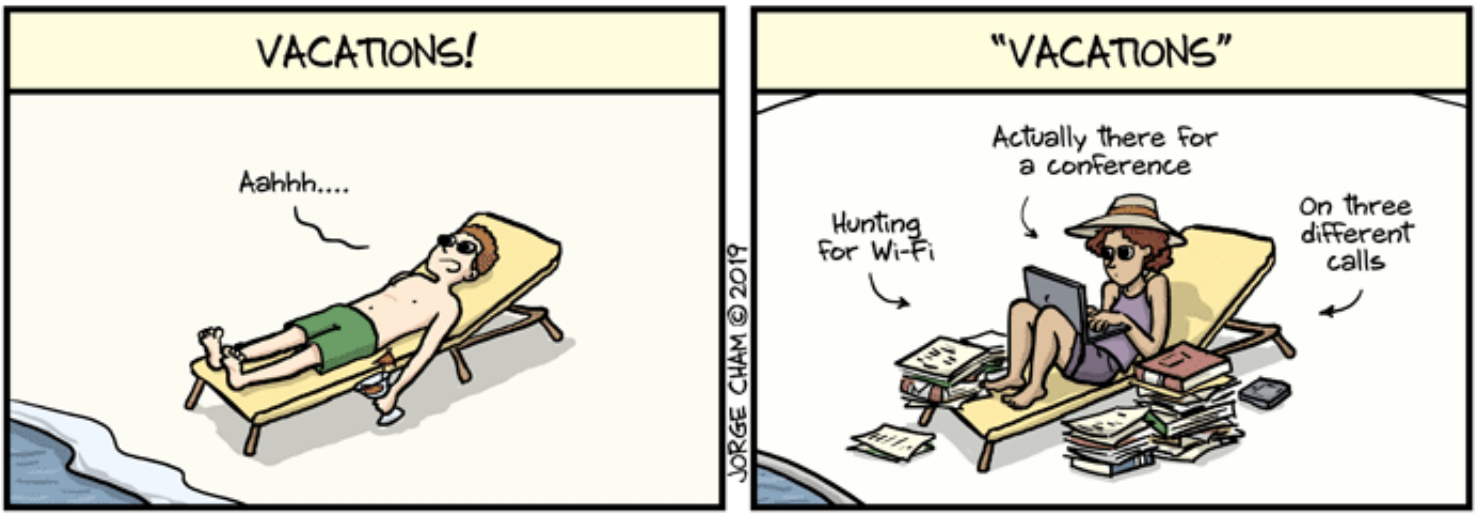
Strawberry Gin Smash



Strawberry Smoothie Bowl



Earl Grey Buckwheat Chocolate Cake



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